against his closest followers in the ashram, who erratically and sometimes sullenly followed his teachings with regard to sex, diet, health, and manual labour; and against himself, as he tested the limits of his physical and emotional endurance through his experiments with celibacy and through his fasts. Gandhi's independence and courage in this regard were to some others merely stubbornness and pig-headedness. But in his pursuit of what he saw as the truth, he was never to be shaken by criticism, even that offered by his family and his closest friends. He was always, in the words of the Tagore song, prepared to walk alone.

Gandhi's religious faith was hard-won—the result of his own exertions and experiences, rather than of received wisdom or ancient texts. In an illuminating passage, Jordens says that while the teachings of a learned philosopher, such as Shankara, could be compared to a 'beautifully woven tapestry, extremely complex, where every colour and every thread takes its proper place in a symphonic whole', the spiritual synthesis Gandhi arrived at was more 'like a large, bulky, woollen shawl. At first it looks very plain to the eye, but we can detect the beauty of the strong patterns and the contrasting shades of folk art. With its knots and unevenness, it feels at first rough to the touch; but soon we can experience how effective it is in warming cold and hungry limbs.'

Among the conventional or traditional Hindu, religious devotion is expressed through the scrupulous observance of rituals, the loving and intense adoration of a personal or family God, or a deep knowledge of the scriptures—or all of the above. On the other hand, the essence of Gandhi's faith consisted of a commitment to truth, chastity, non-violence, and, especially, service. As Jordens writes, 'no school of sect [within Hinduism] did ever elevate the activity of service itself into one that caused the realisation of moksha'—which is what Gandhi did.

In 1936, Gandhi moved to a small hamlet in central India which he renamed Sevagram—the Village of (and for) Service. Gandhi told a friend that he had come here to find